FREE GUIDE FOR COMMERCIAL CLEANING OWNERS

The Run-Without-You Guide

The 25-point checklist that tells you whether your cleaning business runs on systems or runs on you, and the 90-day order for fixing it.

For owners of commercial cleaning and janitorial companies with 5 to 25 employees.

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Why this guide exists

Most commercial cleaning companies between 5 and 25 employees have the same hidden org chart: every road leads back to the owner. You quote the jobs, chase the invoices, answer the crew's questions, smooth over the client complaints, and remember which building needs the floor machine on Thursdays.

That works at $200K. It breaks somewhere between $500K and $1M, because the owner runs out of hours before the business runs out of opportunity.

This is the checklist we use when we pressure-test a service business's operations. Work through the 5 pillars. Every unchecked box is a place where the business depends on your memory instead of a system.

How to use it: check what's true today, not what you plan to fix. Count your checks at the end and use the 90-day plan to close the biggest gaps first.

1

Process

Does the work run without your memory?

- [ ] **Every account has a written scope of work.** Square footage, frequencies, task lists, special requests. Not in your head, not in a text thread. One document per building.
- [ ] **Crews follow checklists, not verbal instructions.** A new hire can walk into any building with a checklist and deliver your standard without calling you.
- [ ] **Site-specific details are documented.** Alarm codes, key locations, supply closets, parking rules, day-porter notes. If your lead tech quit tomorrow, nothing leaves with them.
- [ ] **Quality inspections happen on a schedule, with a form.** Someone other than you walks buildings on a set cadence and scores against the scope.
- [ ] **You have a written onboarding path for new cleaners.** Day 1, week 1, first 30 days. Training happens the same way every time, whether or not you're there.

> **The test:** could a competent operations lead run next week's schedule using only what's written down?

2

Sales Follow-Up

Do leads survive a busy week?

- [ ] **Every lead lands in one system.** Walk-throughs, referrals, website requests, calls. One list, not sticky notes plus a spreadsheet plus your inbox.
- [ ] **Every quote has an automatic follow-up.** Commercial cleaning quotes are won in the follow-up. If a proposal goes quiet for 5 days, something (not someone's memory) nudges it.
- [ ] **You know your pipeline number.** How many open bids, what they're worth, and what's stalled, without asking anyone or digging through email.
- [ ] **Lost bids get a reason code.** Price, timing, incumbent stayed, no response. You can't fix a close rate you can't see.
- [ ] **Renewals and rebids are calendared.** Contract anniversaries and rebid windows exist in a system that reminds you 90 days out, not when the cancellation letter arrives.

> **The test:** if you took two weeks off during your busiest season, would any bid die of neglect?

3

Your Front Door

Does your business sell while you sleep?

- [ ] **Your website makes the next step obvious.** A property manager landing at 9 PM can request a walk-through in under a minute.
- [ ] **Requests get an instant response.** An automatic confirmation goes out immediately, and a human follows within one business day. Speed wins janitorial contracts more often than price does.
- [ ] **Your proof is visible.** Photos of your crews, the buildings you service, testimonials from property and facility managers. Buyers of commercial cleaning are buying reliability, and reliability needs evidence.
- [ ] **You show up when someone searches your name.** Google Business Profile claimed, current, with reviews you actually ask for after every strong quarter.
- [ ] **Someone can find your service list without calling.** Day porter, floor care, post-construction, disinfection. If it's not listed, you're not considered for it.

> **The test:** does your website book walk-throughs, or is it a brochure?

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Automation

Is the repetitive admin off your plate?

- [ ] **Scheduling lives in software, not your head.** Crews see their schedule without texting you. Changes propagate without a phone tree.
- [ ] **Invoices go out on time without you.** Recurring contracts bill automatically on the same day every month. One-time jobs invoice within 48 hours of completion.
- [ ] **Late payments chase themselves.** Reminders at 7, 14, and 30 days fire automatically. You get pulled in at the escalation point, not the first nudge.
- [ ] **Timekeeping is digital and tied to job sites.** Hours flow to payroll without you transcribing anything. You can see labor by account, which is where cleaning margins live or die.
- [ ] **Supply reorders follow a trigger, not a panic.** Par levels or a simple reorder rhythm exist so nobody is buying retail the morning of a strip-and-wax.

> **The test:** how many hours did you spend last week on admin a $25/hr coordinator or a $50/mo tool could own?

5

Financial Clarity

Do you know your numbers cold?

- [ ] **You know margin by account.** Revenue minus labor and supplies per building. Most cleaning companies have 2-3 accounts quietly losing money; owners who don't track this are funding them.
- [ ] **Labor percentage is watched monthly.** Labor runs 50-60% of revenue in this industry. A 3-point drift is a profit crisis you want to see in week 2, not at tax time.
- [ ] **You review a simple monthly scorecard.** Revenue, labor %, new bids, win rate, receivables past 30 days. One page, every month, same format.
- [ ] **Pricing is a formula, not a feeling.** Production rates, loaded labor cost, target margin. Anyone bidding uses the same math, and price protection comes from dropping scope, not dropping rate.
- [ ] **Cash flow is projected, not discovered.** You know what's landing and what's due over the next 60 days. Payroll never depends on which client pays first.

> **The test:** could you say, right now, which account is your least profitable and by how much?

Your score

Count your checked boxes.

Checks	What it means
20-25	You've built a real operating system. Protect it, optimize it, and grow into it.
12-19	Solid foundation with real gaps. The unchecked boxes are pulling you back into the day-to-day. Most owners here can close the biggest gaps in one focused quarter.
0-11	The business runs on you. That's normal, it's how everyone starts, and it's the most fixable problem in business. Start with the 90-day plan below.

The 90-day fix-it order

Don't fix everything at once. This order produces the fastest relief:

Days 1-30: Stop the revenue leaks.

Get every lead into one system and put automatic follow-up on every quote. This is the highest-ROI fix in the entire guide, because it turns work you already did (quoting) into money.

Days 31-60: Get the work out of your head.

Written scopes for your top 5 accounts, crew checklists, and site notes. Start with the accounts that would hurt most to lose.

Days 61-90: Turn on the numbers.

Margin by account, labor % monthly, one-page scorecard. Ten minutes a month on the right page beats a shoebox of good intentions.

Automation and website improvements slot in behind these three. They matter, but follow-up, process, and numbers are what let you finally take that vacation.

When you want help

Business Plans Plus builds the operating system behind growth-stage service businesses: the CRM and follow-up engine, the documented processes, the automation, and the financial visibility. Installed and working, not just recommended.

The fastest starting point is a Business Systems Audit. In 1-2 weeks you get a written bottleneck analysis, a prioritized roadmap, and 1-2 quick wins you keep no matter what. The audit fee is credited in full toward a full build within 30 days. Start at **buildwithbpp.com**.

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